

Democracy and Nationalism, Reconsidered

Steven Denney*

Abstract

Are democratic commitment and nationalism inherently at odds? Much conventional wisdom, and a substantial body of empirical research, suggests they are. Drawing on the 2023 ISSP National Identity module across 29 countries, I show the relationship is more conditional than commonly assumed, because both democracy and nationalism are treated as monolithic when each bundles distinct attitudes. Disaggregating reveals that national pride is largely unrelated to liberal-democratic principles, while satisfaction with democratic performance is positively associated with pride and even with national superiority. Democratic commitment opposes only the exclusionary face of nationalism, above all hostility toward immigrants, and even that opposition depends on how national membership is defined. The restraint holds where nationhood is imagined in civic terms and weakens or reverses where membership is ethnic, including in democracies that are institutionally liberal yet ethnically defined. The content of nationhood, not the liberal quality of institutions, decides when the two conflict.

Keywords: nationalism; democracy; national identity; survey data; ISSP

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I Introduction

Are democratic commitment and nationalism opposed? They are widely assumed to be, because democratic ideals of equality and inclusion appear difficult to reconcile with nationalist claims that distinguish insiders from outsiders. So citizens who prize the first should resist the second. The assumption organizes a large empirical literature. Studies of European publics report that an ethnic conception of nationhood depresses support for democracy (Gabrielsson, Hjerm and Eger, 2025) and predicts hostility to immigrants (Hjerm, 1998; Pehrson, Vignoles and Brown, 2009), and recent comparative work often treats the negative relationship as near-universal. The same premise frames the literature on Chinese popular nationalism. Zhong and Hwang (2020, p. 62) note that “people with more liberal democratic values tend to be less nationalistic” before reporting the opposite for China, as does later nationwide work (Liu and Xiao, 2026).

Yet this assumption that democratic commitment and nationalism are inherently opposed outruns the evidence and rests on a simplified reading of both concepts. The two developed together in the modern era, and liberal-nationalist theorists have long argued that national solidarity can sustain democratic self-government rather than undermine it (Tamir, 2019). Recent work presses the point with new evidence. Hur (2022; 2026) shows that national attachment has underwritten democratic civic duty in South Korea, so that nationalism can strengthen democracy rather than corrode it. I share that starting point but reach it by disaggregating each concept, which brings a complication into view that a duty-centered account leaves aside. Where nationhood is ethnically bounded, as in Korea, commitment to democratic rights ceases to restrain the exclusionary face of nationalism. More fundamentally, neither “democracy” nor “nationalism” is a single attitude. Each is a bundle of distinct orientations, and how they relate depends on which components one has in mind and in which countries and regions one examines them.

This is an especially useful moment to revisit the question. Nationalism has returned to the center of political debate, where it is frequently equated with nativism, democratic backsliding, and right-wing populism (Mudde, 2007; Brubaker, 2017). At the same time, new comparative data make it possible to test a long-standing assumption that has more often been asserted than examined, and to do so beyond the Western democracies on which the prevailing verdict was largely built. The 2023 ISSP National Identity and Citizenship module is the only cross-national survey that measures the content of nationhood and

multiple forms of nationalism alongside citizens' democratic commitments. Fielded in 29 countries, including consolidated Western democracies, post-communist Europe, several electoral autocracies, the institutionally liberal democracies of East Asia, and others such as Israel, Mexico, and South Africa, it opens an opportunity to examine when democratic commitment and nationalism coincide and when they conflict.

This article therefore disaggregates both concepts and asks a more precise question: for which components, and under what conditions, is commitment to democracy antagonistic to nationalism? There are two main findings to report.

First, democratic commitment and nationalism are not general opposites. Endorsement of liberal-democratic rights is essentially unrelated to ordinary national pride, while perceived democratic performance is positively associated with pride and even with national superiority across regions. Democratic commitment opposes the narrower exclusionary face of nationalism, above all hostility toward immigrants. Second, even this conflict is conditional. The negative association between democratic-rights endorsement and exclusion is strongest where the nation is imagined in civic terms and weakens, disappears, or even reverses where membership is understood in ethnocultural terms.

This conditional pattern matters theoretically because it is not what a focus on regime type would predict. The pattern is governed by the civic-versus-ethnic content of nationhood rather than by the liberal-democratic quality of political institutions. South Korea and Taiwan, for example, have converged on the institutions of liberal democracy, yet citizens who value democratic rights are no less exclusionary and are somewhat more attached to ascriptive conceptions of nationhood. In multilevel models, the content of nationhood moderates how strongly democratic-rights endorsement restrains exclusion, while institutional liberalism (V-Dem's liberal component) adds no detectable moderation of its own once the content of nationhood is included.

The contribution of this article is to revise a stubborn assumption. Democratic commitment and nationalism do not stand in a generally antagonistic relationship. The conflict is confined to liberal-democratic rights and the exclusionary face of nationalism, and only where nationhood is understood in civic terms. Following Tamir (2019), the relevant divide is often between liberal and illiberal orientations

rather than between democracy and nationalism as such. And following the contextual logic of Pehrson, Vignoles, and Brown (2009), whether that divide becomes politically meaningful depends on how the national community is bounded. I show that the same contextual logic governs the relationship between democratic commitment and exclusion, and I pit the content of nationhood directly against institutional liberalism. The apparent law that democracy restrains nationalism turns out to be a feature of civic-national political cultures rather than a property of democratic commitment itself. This matters when nationalism is routinely equated with nativism and right-wing populism, because it shows what restrains exclusion and in which countries.

2 Disaggregating democracy and nationalism

Neither key term denotes a single attitude. Treating democracy and nationalism as bundles of distinct orientations helps explain the conflicting findings in the literature.

Regarding democracy, two orientations must be kept apart. The first is normative commitment to the *principles* of liberal democracy, especially the rights that protect minorities and enable participation and dissent. The second is evaluation of democratic *performance*, how well the system is seen to work. Norris (1999) documented that publics distinguish principled support from performance satisfaction, and that the two need not coincide. The distinction matters because “democracy” is a contested concept. People endorse it while loading it with majoritarian or authoritarian meaning, and abstract support conceals “illiberal democrats” who reject the liberal principles that define the regime (Kirsch and Welzel, 2019; Schedler and Sarsfield, 2007). The ISSP allows the separation directly, asking how important various rights are *for democracy* (principles) and, separately, how well democracy *works today* (performance).

For nationalism, the relevant distinction is between *exclusionary* content and ordinary *attachment*. Since Kosterman and Feshbach (1989), survey research has separated chauvinism and perceived superiority from patriotic pride, and recent work treats popular nationalism as a set of separable components rather than a single thing (Bonikowski and DiMaggio, 2016; Bonikowski, 2017). The exclusionary components include an ascriptive definition of who truly belongs (by birth or ancestry), beliefs in national superiority,

and hostility to immigrants, central to nativism (Mudde, 2007). National pride in collective achievements is conceptually distinct, and pride and exclusion need not co-occur (Hjerm, 1998). Conflating them makes “nationalism” appear uniformly anti-democratic.

Putting the two disaggregations together yields the article’s first expectation. If the tension is between liberal commitment and exclusion rather than between democracy and nationalism as such, democratic-rights endorsement should be negatively related to exclusionary nationalism and largely unrelated to national pride, while performance evaluations, which capture satisfaction rather than liberal principle, should relate positively to pride.

E1 (two faces of nationalism). Endorsement of liberal-democratic rights is negatively associated with exclusionary nationalism and essentially unrelated to national pride. Perceived democratic performance is positively associated with pride.

The harder question is whether the negative rights–exclusion relationship holds everywhere. Two readings diverge here. On a regime-centered reading, *institutional* liberalism is what restrains exclusion, so the negative relationship should strengthen with the liberal quality of a country’s democracy. On a culture-centered reading, the *content* of nationhood is what matters, so the relationship should depend on whether the nation is defined in civic or ethnic terms. Brubaker (1992) distinguishes civic from ethnic traditions of nationhood.¹ Using earlier ISSP rounds, Pehrson and colleagues (2009) show that the link between national identification and anti-immigrant prejudice is conditional on the *national definition* prevailing in a country. It is strong where nationhood is defined in ethnocultural (chiefly linguistic) terms and weak where it is defined civically. The two readings diverge for cases where they come apart, in particular East Asian democracies, institutionally liberal yet retaining strongly ethnic conceptions of the nation (Shin, 2006).

E2 (scope condition). The negative association between democratic-rights endorsement and exclusion is moderated by the civic-versus-ethnic content of nationhood, not by institutional

¹The civic/ethnic distinction is a heuristic, not a strict binary or a typology of good and bad nationalisms, and a civic conception is not thereby fully inclusive (Simonsen and Bonikowski, 2020). The contrast lies in the kind of demand a community places on its members. Civic demands, such as participation and accepting shared institutions, are in principle achievable rather than ascribed at birth.

liberalism. It is strong where the prevailing conception is civic and weak or reversed where it is ethnic.

E2 predicts cross-national heterogeneity in the rights–exclusion relationship, and it predicts that the heterogeneity tracks the content of nationhood rather than regime type.

3 Data, measures, and approach

The data used here are the ISSP 2023 National Identity and Citizenship module (ISSP Research Group, 2026), 43,517 respondents in 29 countries. All items are rescaled to the unit interval, oriented so higher values mean more of the named concept. Descriptive estimates use the combined ISSP weight. The *democratic-rights* measure averages three items on the importance for democracy of protecting minority rights, expanding participation, and permitting civil disobedience. *Democratic performance* is the single item on how well democracy works today (SI-A gives full wording). Nationalism is split into ascriptive membership, civic membership, national superiority, anti-immigrant exclusion, protectionism, and national pride (excluding pride in democracy). Anti-immigrant exclusion is the primary outcome; ascriptive membership, superiority, and pride are secondary, and protectionism is set aside as conceptually distinct from exclusion. Individual controls are age, gender, education, and left–right self-placement. Country-level institutional liberalism comes from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project’s liberal-component index (`v2x_liberal`) for 2023, and its electoral component (`v2x_polyarchy`) is the contrast (Coppedge et al., 2025). The SI gives full item wording, coding, and descriptive statistics (SI-A), with scale reliabilities in SI-C.

Two measurement issues deserve attention. The democratic-rights battery is unique to the 2023 module, so the central relationship cannot be traced over time, and the relational analysis is cross-sectional by necessity; the SI places the 2023 *levels* of exclusionary nationalism in their 1995–2023 trajectory (SI-K). The attitude scales are also not fully comparable across these societies. Multi-group confirmatory factor analyses reproduce the expected factor structure (configural invariance holds) but decisively reject the equality of intercepts needed to compare scale *means* (scalar invariance fails, with the comparative fit

index dropping by 0.11 to 0.23). The loadings that govern *associations* are more comparable, though the change in them modestly exceeds the conventional 0.01 threshold. I therefore treat metric invariance as approximate and compare within-context associations, not levels (SI-D). The anti-immigrant scale is the least equivalent of the set, so its country-level estimates are read with corresponding caution. This is the pattern earlier work documents for ISSP nationalism scales (Reeskens and Hooghe, 2010).

Respondents are nested in countries, and I ask whether a within-person relationship varies across contexts. I therefore estimate multilevel models with random intercepts and a random slope on the democratic-rights index, centered on each country's mean so the slope is the within-country relationship. I then test whether that slope differs by two country-level features, the content of nationhood (the country mean of ascriptive membership, standardized across countries) and institutional liberalism (the standardized V-Dem liberal component), entered together so the two compete. I report unweighted model-based estimates in the main text and design-based weighted estimates as a robustness check in the SI, and they agree. The adjusted models are estimated on complete cases ($n = 37,177$ for anti-immigrant exclusion), limited mainly by missing left-right placement. Given the very large sample, I emphasize the size and sign of the within-country relationships rather than statistical significance. The cross-level interactions, by contrast, are identified from only 29 countries, so I corroborate them with a country-level second stage (SI-F) and read the institutional-liberalism comparison with corresponding caution.

4 Results

4.1 The conventional pattern is not universal

The simple correlations already show that democratic-rights endorsement restrains exclusion only in the West. Within Western democracies, democratic-rights endorsement is negatively correlated with every exclusionary measure (-0.23 with anti-immigrant exclusion, -0.15 with ascriptive membership, -0.14 with superiority) and essentially zero with pride (-0.03). Outside the West the pattern frays and inverts. In the East Asian democracies the same endorsement is *positively* correlated with ascriptive membership ($+0.09$), superiority ($+0.07$), and pride ($+0.09$), and unrelated to anti-immigrant exclusion (-0.02), and

in the electoral autocracies the exclusionary correlations are positive. The full grid is in SI-H.

4.2 The relationship reverses across countries

Multilevel models confirm that the rights–exclusion relationship is not one fixed number but varies across countries. Across the four outcomes the random slope has a standard deviation between 0.10 and 0.14, as large as or larger than the average slope itself, so how much the relationship differs across countries matters as much as its average. Conceptions of nationhood are themselves highly clustered by country (intraclass correlation 0.32 for ascriptive membership). Figure 1 plots the country-specific adjusted slopes for anti-immigrant exclusion. They range from about -0.33 in the United States to $+0.30$ in Hungary, with Western democracies at the negative end and the two East Asian democracies at zero (SI-I gives the other outcomes).

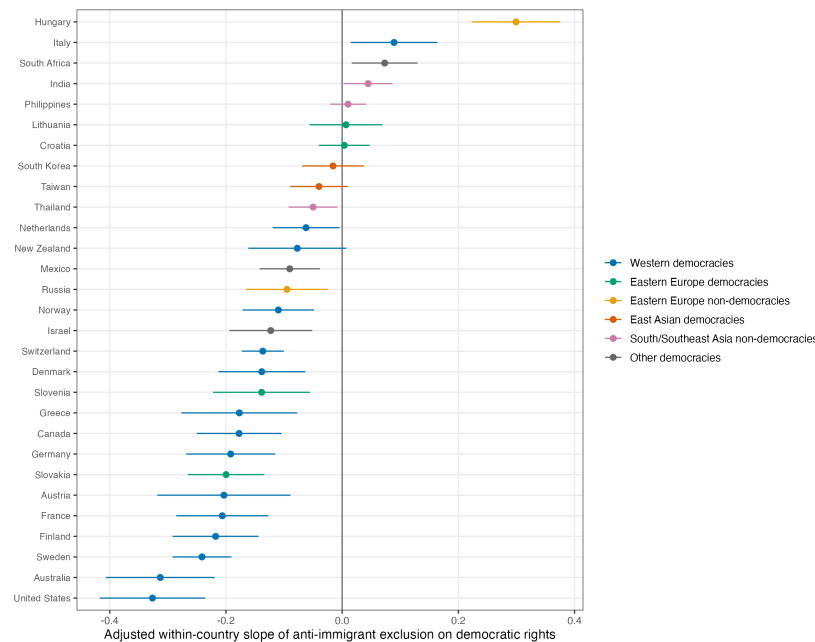


Figure 1: Cross-national heterogeneity in the rights–exclusion relationship

Note: Each point is a country's *within*-country slope of anti-immigrant exclusion on democratic-rights endorsement, adjusted for age, gender, education, and left–right placement; bars are 95% confidence intervals. Color denotes region-regime group, and the vertical line marks zero, so negative values mean democratic-rights endorsement restrains exclusion. $n = 37,177$ complete cases in 29 countries.

4.3 National content, not political institutions

What accounts for the spread? Figure 2 puts the two candidate moderators side by side. Where the nation is imagined in civic terms, as in Canada, the United States, and Sweden (the low-ascriptive end of Panel A), rights endorsement strongly restrains exclusion. Where it is imagined ethnically, the restraining relationship vanishes (Panel A, $r = 0.65$). Against institutional liberalism the slopes are weak and scattered (Panel B, $r = -0.33$), and South Korea and Taiwan score high on V-Dem's liberal component yet sit at the zero line, alongside far less liberal cases.

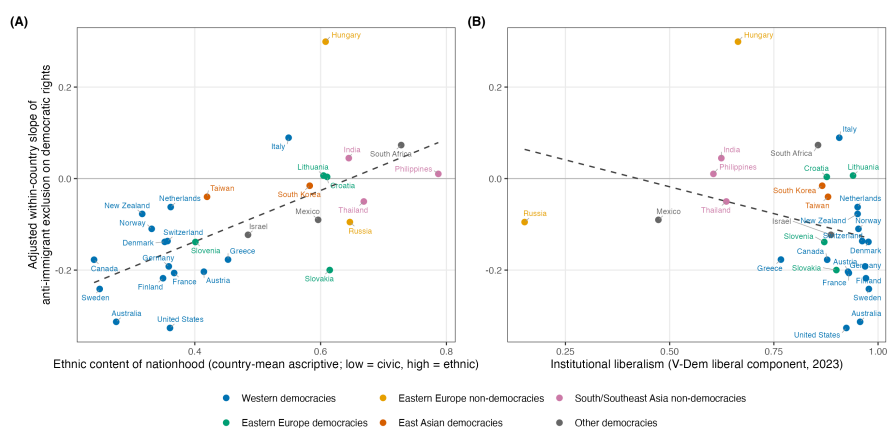


Figure 2: The content of nationhood moderates the rights–exclusion slope; institutional liberalism does not
Note: Each point is a country, plotting its adjusted slope (as in Figure 1) against a candidate moderator; the dashed line is the bivariate fit. Panel (A) uses the civic–ethnic content of nationhood (country-mean ascriptive membership; low values civic, high ethnic), where the association is strong ($r = 0.65$). Panel (B) uses institutional liberalism (V-Dem liberal component, 2023), where it is weak and scattered ($r = -0.33$). South Korea and Taiwan score high on V-Dem's liberal component yet sit at the zero line.

The multilevel models settle the comparison by entering both moderators at once (full coefficients, random effects, and implied slopes in SI-E). The cross-level interaction between democratic-rights endorsement and the ethnic content of nationhood is positive and clearly estimated for anti-immigrant exclusion ($b = 0.108$, $SE = 0.027$) and for ascriptive membership ($b = 0.088$, $SE = 0.027$). The interaction with institutional liberalism, entered in the same model, is indistinguishable from zero ($b = 0.020$, $SE = 0.027$ for anti-immigrant exclusion, and $b = -0.006$ for ascriptive membership). Institutional liberalism shows no detectable independent moderation once the content of nationhood is in the model. A country-level second stage returns the same verdict (SI-F). In the content-only model, the implied within-country slope

for anti-immigrant exclusion weakens from -0.22 where the nation is civic (one standard deviation below the mean on ethnic content) to -0.03 where it is ethnic (one standard deviation above). For ascriptive membership it crosses zero, from -0.13 to $+0.05$. The reversal is not an artifact of the regime classification, the choice of index, or the weighting scheme (Section SI-J).

4.4 Two faces of democratic commitment

The two democracy measures relate to nationalism in opposite ways, and that contrast shows where democracy and nationalism align. Figure 3 contrasts the pooled within-country slopes for democratic *principles* (rights endorsement) and democratic *performance* (full models in SI-G). Principled commitment is negative for the exclusionary outcomes and weakly positive for pride, at -0.12 for anti-immigrant exclusion, -0.05 for superiority, -0.04 for ascriptive membership, and $+0.05$ for pride. Democratic *performance* runs in the opposite direction. People who think democracy works well are markedly *prouder* of their country (0.26), more likely to endorse national *superiority* (0.14), and more attached to civic membership (0.08), even as they too are less anti-immigrant (-0.14). This positive tie between democratic performance and pride, and even chauvinism, holds in every region, and it is the plainest sign that democratic commitment and nationalism are not opposed.

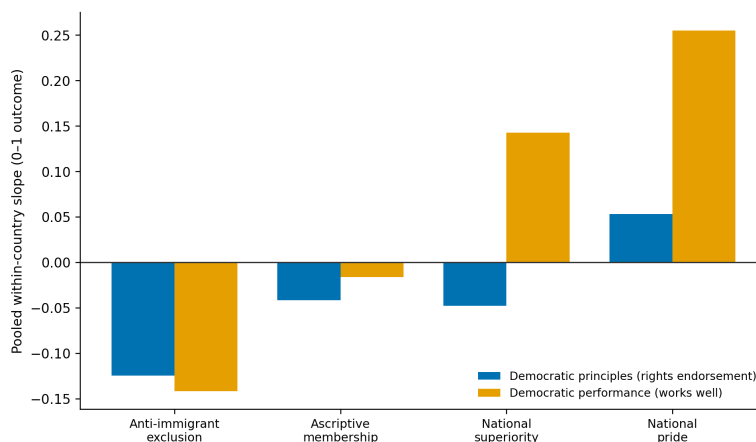


Figure 3: Two faces of democratic commitment

Note: Pooled within-country slopes of each nationalism outcome on two democracy measures, democratic principles (endorsement of liberal-democratic rights) and democratic performance (how well democracy is seen to work). Principled commitment restrains exclusion without dampening pride, whereas performance evaluations travel *with* pride and superiority. Full performance models are in SI-G.

One performance result is mechanical. People who rate democracy as working well are, unsurprisingly, prouder of “the way democracy works,” a near-tautology sometimes reported as a finding. The substantive result is the positive association with pride in non-democratic achievements and with superiority.

5 Discussion

The central finding is easy to misstate, so it is best to be precise. Democratic commitment and nationalism are not general opposites. National pride is untouched by liberal commitment and rises with satisfaction in democratic performance. Democratic commitment restrains only the exclusionary face of nationalism. Even that restraint depends on how the nation is imagined. It holds where the nation is imagined in civic terms and lapses where it is imagined ethnically, governed by the content of nationhood rather than the liberal quality of institutions. Tamir (2019) states this more clearly. The real divide runs between liberal and illiberal orientations, and whether it surfaces depends on how the nation draws its boundaries.

The East Asian democracies are especially instructive about regional difference, and they complicate readings centered on regime type. By V-Dem’s measures and the broader scholarly consensus, Taiwan and South Korea have converged on the institutions of liberal democracy, yet their citizens who most value democratic rights are no less exclusionary and are somewhat more attached to an ascriptive nation.² The likeliest reason is historical rather than institutional. In Korea and Taiwan, national mobilization was bound up with democratization (Shin, 2006; Chu, 2004), and a genealogical or ethnic understanding of the nation carried into the democratic era (Shin, 2006). Where democracy was built by affirming the nation, democratic commitment and national attachment are complements, and “democratic rights” are understood inside a national project rather than against its ethnic boundaries. This complementarity is what Hur’s (2022; 2026) account of Korea describes, in which national attachment supplies the civic duty that sustains democratic participation. The evidence presented here is consistent with that account

²Taiwan and South Korea differ. South Korea’s genealogical conception of the nation remains strong (Hur, 2022; Jo, 2025), whereas Taiwan has reoriented toward a civic, territorial self-understanding defined against the Han nationalism of the mainland and bound up with its democracy (Wachman, 1994; Ho, 2022). A comparative list experiment across the two cases documents the contrast (Denney, Steinhardt and Bhowmick, 2026). Taiwan’s mean ascriptive endorsement (0.42) falls below South Korea’s (0.58), so the restraining relationship flattens rather than reverses there.

and draws out its less benign corollary. The ethnically grounded nationhood that makes nationalism a democratic resource is what keeps democratic-rights commitment from restraining exclusion, so the restraint typical of the civic West is absent in Korea rather than merely weaker. This also reframes the “puzzle” of Chinese popular nationalism, in which democratic-minded citizens are more nationalistic (Zhong and Hwang, 2020; Liu and Xiao, 2026).³ Usually attributed to regime discontent under authoritarianism, that pattern looks, in light of the East Asian democracies, more like a feature of ethnically grounded nationhood than an artifact of autocracy.

These reorientations are recent and generational, the clearest sign that the contrast is one of democratic trajectory rather than a fixed East–West divide. Taiwanese socialized entirely under democratic institutions hold a markedly more civic conception of nationhood than their elders and converge on the established civic democracies, and among that cohort the rights–exclusion relationship reorients toward the restraining, civic pattern. South Korea, which democratized later and has reoriented its national project less, shows little such shift (see subgroup correlations, SI-L).

Two alternative readings deserve comment. Status-anxiety and cultural-backlash accounts (Gidron and Hall, 2017; Norris and Inglehart, 2019) explain why some citizens embrace exclusion, but neither predicts that the rights–exclusion relationship should flip with the content of nationhood. Both concern who is exclusionary, not what democratic commitment does. Brubaker’s (2017) civilizationism, in which liberalism itself is enlisted against Muslims especially, is the boundary case the scope condition anticipates. Where the nation is bounded ethnically or civilizational, liberal commitment stops restraining exclusion, and the East Asian democracies make the point without the civilizational frame.

Three limitations in particular are important to note. First, the design is cross-sectional, so the relationships are associations rather than effects, and I make no causal claim about which way they run. Second, the moderator (the content of nationhood) comes from the same survey family as the outcomes, and for the ascriptive outcome the country mean and individual response are mechanically related. I therefore lead with anti-immigrant exclusion, where moderator and outcome are distinct, and treat the

³In Liu and Xiao’s data the association is with a *substantive*, state-congruent conception of democracy, not commitment to liberal-democratic rights.

ascriptive result as corroborating. Third, the cross-level comparison rests on 29 countries, most of them institutionally liberal, so the flat interaction for V-Dem's liberal component is best read as no *detectable* independent role for institutions rather than proof of none. The scales are also not scalar-invariant, which is why I compare relationships rather than levels.

The practical implication is worth stating plainly. If one hopes that deepening citizens' commitment to democratic rights will, by itself, hold nativism in check, the evidence counsels against optimism. That hope is warranted where the nation is already understood as a civic community and misplaced where it is understood ethnically. What restrains exclusion is a civic conception of who belongs, a feature of political culture that democratic institutions cannot guarantee.

Data availability

The ISSP 2023 National Identity module (ZA10010) and the earlier ISSP rounds used in the longitudinal appendix are publicly available from the GESIS Data Archive, and V-Dem v15 is accessed through the `vdemdata` R package. Replication code is available in the public repository accompanying this working paper (SI-M).

Artificial intelligence

Anthropic's Claude Opus (4.7 and 4.8), an agentic AI system, was used for adversarial pre-submission review, coding and replication checks, and the formatting of tables and figures. The author stands by the prose as their own and the ideas as uniquely theirs.

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Supplementary Information

Democracy and Nationalism, Reconsidered

Steven Denney*

This supplement documents data, measures, measurement-comparability tests, the full multilevel results, robustness checks, and a descriptive longitudinal panel. Section numbers are referenced from the main text. All analyses use ISSP 2023 (ZA10010 v1.0.0); country-level moderators use V-Dem v15 (2023 values).

SI-A. Measures and coding

All items are rescaled to $[0, 1]$ and oriented so higher = more of the named concept. ISSP WEIGHT_COM (combined weight) is used for the descriptive and reliability estimates, normalized for pooled estimates so each country contributes equally; the multilevel models in the main text are unweighted, with design-weighted versions reported as a robustness check (SI-J). Item codings were verified against the ZA10010 value labels.

Construct	ISSP items (2023)	Scaling
Democratic rights (principles)	v42 minority rights, v43 participation, v44 civil disobedience (“how important <i>for democracy</i> ”, 1–7)	$(x - 1)/6$; higher = more important
Democratic performance	v38 “how well does democracy work in [country] today” (0–10)	$x/10$; higher = works well

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Construct	ISSP items (2023)	Scaling
Ascriptive membership	v1 born, v3 religion, v6 ancestry (1–4 importance); v13 born-not-effort	reverse to higher = more ascriptive
Civic membership	v2 citizenship, v4 respect institutions, v5 feel national	higher = more important
National superiority	v9 world better if like us, v10 better than most, v11 support when wrong (1–5 agree)	higher = more agreement
Anti-immigrant exclusion	v26 crime, v27 economy (rev.), v28 jobs, v29 ideas (rev.), v30 native preference, v31 reduce number	higher = more exclusionary
Protectionism	v20–v25 (imports, sovereignty, foreign land, etc.)	higher = more protectionist
National pride	v15–v19 (political influence, economy, sports, arts, history); pride in democracy (v14) excluded	higher = prouder

Table SI-1: Constructs, ISSP 2023 items, and scaling

Note: All items rescaled to [0, 1], oriented so higher means more of the named concept.

Individual controls: age (years), gender (female = 1), education (ISCED 0–8), left–right self-placement (v46, 0–10, rescaled to the unit interval). The democratic-rights battery (v41–v44) is unique to the 2023 module; earlier ISSP National Identity rounds (1995/2003/2013) do not field it, which is why the relational analysis is cross-sectional (see SI-K).

The four-item democratic-rights index (adding v41, “adequate standard of living”) mixes liberal rights with welfare commitments; the three-item liberal-rights index is used in the main analysis. Results are unchanged with the four-item version.

SI-B. Countries, V-Dem indices, and the content of nationhood

29 countries, $N = 43,517$. Countries are ordered by the civic–ethnic content of nationhood (country-mean ascriptive membership), the main moderator. Note that East Asian democracies (Taiwan, South Korea) score high on V-Dem’s liberal component yet have markedly more ascriptive conceptions of nationhood than the Western core.

Country	Region-regime group	V-Dem RoW 2023	Liberal comp.	Electoral comp.	Mean ascriptive	N
Canada	Western dem.	Electoral dem.	0.88	0.85	0.24	2,127
Sweden	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.98	0.88	0.25	1,607
Australia	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.96	0.85	0.28	993
New Zealand	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.95	0.88	0.32	1,191
Norway	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.95	0.88	0.33	1,132
Finland	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.97	0.86	0.35	1,369
Denmark	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.98	0.92	0.35	1,254
Switzerland	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.96	0.89	0.36	3,202
Germany	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.97	0.85	0.36	1,545
United States	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.92	0.84	0.36	1,589
Netherlands	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.95	0.84	0.36	1,509
France	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.93	0.88	0.37	1,905
Slovenia	E. Europe dem.	Electoral dem.	0.87	0.76	0.40	1,039
Austria	Western dem.	Electoral dem.	0.93	0.85	0.41	1,146
Taiwan	E. Asian dem.	Liberal dem.	0.88	0.82	0.42	1,563
Greece	Western dem.	Electoral dem.	0.77	0.74	0.45	1,463
Israel	Other dem.	Electoral dem.	0.89	0.72	0.48	1,197
Italy	Western dem.	Liberal dem.	0.91	0.82	0.55	1,135
South Korea	E. Asian dem.	Liberal dem.	0.87	0.73	0.58	1,230
Mexico	Other dem.	Electoral dem.	0.47	0.55	0.60	1,025
Lithuania	E. Europe dem.	Electoral dem.	0.94	0.79	0.60	1,257
Hungary	E. Europe non-dem.	Electoral autoc.	0.66	0.44	0.61	1,023
Croatia	E. Europe dem.	Electoral dem.	0.88	0.74	0.61	1,400
Slovakia	E. Europe dem.	Electoral dem.	0.90	0.82	0.61	1,025
India	S/SE Asia non-dem.	Electoral autoc.	0.62	0.37	0.64	1,605
Russia	E. Europe non-dem.	Electoral autoc.	0.15	0.19	0.65	1,574
Thailand	S/SE Asia non-dem.	Electoral autoc.	0.64	0.29	0.67	1,500
South Africa	Other dem.	Electoral dem.	0.86	0.70	0.73	3,112

Country	Region-regime group	V-Dem RoW 2023	Liberal comp.	Electoral comp.	Mean ascriptive	<i>N</i>
Philippines	S/SE Asia non-dem.	Electoral autoc.	0.60	0.43	0.79	1,800

Table SI-2: Countries, V-Dem indices, and the content of nationhood

Note: Ordered by the civic–ethnic content of nationhood (country-mean ascriptive membership). East Asian democracies (Taiwan, South Korea) score high on the liberal component yet are markedly more ascriptive.

The simple regime binary used for robustness (SI-J) codes V-Dem liberal and electoral democracies as democracies and electoral/closed autocracies as non-democracies, yielding 24 democracies and 5 non-democracies (Hungary, India, Philippines, Russia, Thailand).

SI-C. Scale reliability by region-regime group

Cronbach's α (unweighted). The democratic-rights index is modest in the West ($\alpha = 0.50$) and stronger elsewhere; the anti-immigrant index is strong in Western and East European democracies but weak in South/Southeast Asia, foreshadowing the non-invariance documented in SI-D.

Group	Dem. rights	Ascriptive	Superiority	Anti-immigrant	Pride
Western democracies	0.50	0.75	0.59	0.86	0.66
Eastern Europe democracies	0.77	0.68	0.73	0.79	0.70
Eastern Europe non-democracies	0.63	0.64	0.80	0.74	0.83
East Asian democracies	0.57	0.71	0.46	0.65	0.67
South/SE Asia non-democracies	0.70	0.49	0.62	0.37	0.74
Other democracies	0.67	0.56	0.61	0.67	0.74

Table SI-3: Scale reliability (Cronbach's α) by region-regime group

Note: Unweighted Cronbach's α . The anti-immigrant index is weak in South/Southeast Asia, foreshadowing SI-D.

SI-D. Measurement invariance

The analysis compares *associations* across contexts, not scale means, and the invariance tests justify exactly that restriction. A multi-group confirmatory factor analysis across the six region-regime groups (ML, with FIML for missingness) tests configural, metric, and scalar invariance, using the decision rule $\Delta\text{CFI} \geq -0.010$ (Cheung and Rensvold, 2002).

Scale	Level	CFI	RMSEA	SRMR	ΔCFI
Anti-immigrant (6)	configural	0.904	0.133	0.052	—
	metric	0.880	0.123	0.065	−0.024
	scalar	0.722	0.163	0.119	−0.158
Ascriptive (4)	configural	0.993	0.054	0.015	—
	metric	0.981	0.060	0.035	−0.012
	scalar	0.874	0.122	0.093	−0.107
Superiority (3)	configural	1.000	0.000	0.000	—
	metric	0.968	0.091	0.042	−0.032
	scalar	0.775	0.172	0.090	−0.193
Democratic rights (3)	configural	1.000	0.000	0.000	—
	metric	0.977	0.072	0.032	−0.023
	scalar	0.747	0.168	0.091	−0.230

Table SI-4: Multi-group measurement invariance across the six region-regime groups

Note: Metric invariance permits comparison of associations; scalar invariance, required to compare scale *means*, is decisively rejected for every scale (ΔCFI from -0.11 to -0.23).

Configural invariance holds. Metric invariance is only approximate. The loading-equality fit change runs from -0.012 to -0.032 , modestly beyond the conventional -0.010 guideline for all four scales, but an order of magnitude smaller than the scalar change. Scalar invariance is decisively rejected (ΔCFI from -0.11 to -0.23), so latent *means* are not comparable across contexts. Comparing within-context *associations* relies on equal loadings, not equal intercepts, and the alignment results below show loadings are more comparable across contexts than intercepts. I therefore compare relationships rather than means throughout, and I read the least-invariant scale (anti-immigrant) with added caution. This is close to the canonical metric-near, scalar-no verdict for ISSP nationalism scales (Davidov, 2009; Reeskens and Hooghe, 2010).

Alignment across the 29 countries (the alignment method; Asparouhov and Muthén, 2014) corrobo-

rates the ordering. For the ascriptive scale, the average cross-country correlation of aligned parameters ($\bar{r}$) is higher for loadings than for intercepts (0.72 vs. 0.53), so the loadings that govern associations are again more comparable than the intercepts that govern means. The anti-immigrant scale is the least invariant of the set ($\bar{r}$ for loadings = 0.08), consistent with its low α in South/Southeast Asia, so its country-level estimates are read with caution.

By design, all inferences rest on within-context associations and slopes, and no raw scale mean is compared across countries. I treat the cross-context variation in measurement as substantively meaningful rather than as nuisance, because the content of nationhood itself differs.

SI-E. Multilevel models (full)

Individuals (i) nested in countries (j). The predictor (democratic-rights endorsement) is group-mean-centered so the slope is the within-country relationship; its country mean enters at level 2 (grand-mean-centered). Level-2 moderators are standardized across the 29 countries: $z_content$ is the country-mean of ascriptive membership (higher = more ethnic conception of nationhood), $z_liberal$ is the standardized V-Dem liberal component. Models are estimated by ML; p -values use the normal approximation (justified by the large N). Outcomes are on the 0–1 scale.

Outcome	SD intercept	SD slope	corr(int,slope)	SD residual	ICC
Anti-immigrant exclusion	0.089	0.145	0.48	0.176	0.20
Ascriptive membership	0.147	0.140	0.65	0.213	0.32
National superiority	0.063	0.100	0.51	0.196	0.09
National pride	0.046	0.098	0.20	0.184	0.06

Table SI-5: Random-effects structure and ICC (model M1, random intercept and random slope)

Note: The democratic-rights slope is group-mean-centered. The random-slope SD (0.10–0.14) is as large as or larger than the average slope, indicating substantial cross-national heterogeneity.

The random-slope SD (0.10–0.14) is as large as or larger than the average slope, confirming substantial cross-national heterogeneity in the democratic-rights relationship. The focal cross-level interactions in SI-E are pre-specified. I report significance markers only as a guide and rest interpretation on effect size, and I apply no multiple-comparisons correction to the secondary outcomes.

Outcome	Dem-rights slope (M1)	× ethnic content	× liberal comp.
Anti-immigrant exclusion	−0.125 (0.027)***	+0.108 (0.027)***	+0.020 (0.027)
Ascriptive membership	−0.042 (0.027)	+0.088 (0.027)**	−0.006 (0.027)
National superiority	−0.048 (0.020)*	+0.035 (0.021)	−0.030 (0.021)
National pride	+0.053 (0.019)**	+0.027 (0.023)	−0.008 (0.023)

Outcome	Dem-rights slope (M1)	× ethnic content	× liberal comp.
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Table SI-6: Average within-country slope (M1) and cross-level interactions (M3, both moderators entered together)
Note: SEs in parentheses; *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$. The interaction with the ethnic content of nationhood is positive and well-estimated for the two exclusion measures, while the interaction with institutional liberalism, entered in the same model, is indistinguishable from zero throughout.

SEs in parentheses. *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$. The interaction with the *content of nationhood* is positive and well-estimated for the two exclusion measures (the restraining slope weakens as the conception becomes more ethnic); the interaction with *institutional liberalism*, entered in the same model, is indistinguishable from zero throughout.

The implied within-country slopes by content of nationhood (model M2) follow, where “civic” is one SD below mean ascriptive content and “ethnic” is one SD above.

Outcome	Civic context (−1 SD)	Mean	Ethnic context (+1 SD)
Anti-immigrant exclusion	−0.220	−0.125	−0.030
Ascriptive membership	−0.133	−0.042	+0.050
National superiority	−0.102	−0.048	+0.005
National pride	+0.021	+0.053	+0.085

Table SI-7: Implied within-country slope by content of nationhood (M2)

Note: “Civic” and “ethnic” contexts are one SD below and above the cross-country mean of ascriptive content. The restraining slope weakens, and for ascriptive membership reverses, as content turns ethnic.

SI-F. Country-level second stage (slopes regressed on moderators)

A two-step check corroborates the multilevel interaction. Country-specific within-country correlations (the raw counterpart to the controls-adjusted slopes plotted in the main text’s Figure 2) are regressed on the standardized moderators across the 29 countries. The moderator is oriented as in the main text, so the ethnic content of nationhood (country-mean ascriptive membership) carries a positive sign.

The bivariate correlations of the anti-immigrant slope come first. The slope correlates with the ethnic content of nationhood at $r = +0.71$ (more ethnic content means a less restraining, more positive slope), with the V-Dem liberal component at $r = -0.37$, and with the electoral component at $r = -0.53$. This

is the same relationship the main text's Figure 2 shows for the adjusted slopes ($r = +0.65$), so the raw and adjusted second stages agree.

A head-to-head OLS with standardized predictors compares the two moderators directly. For anti-immigrant exclusion, ethnic content carries $\beta = +0.12$ ($p < 0.001$) while the V-Dem liberal component carries $\beta = +0.02$ ($p = 0.50$), with adjusted $R^2 = 0.48$. For ascriptive membership, content carries $\beta = +0.10$ ($p < 0.001$) and the liberal component $\beta = -0.01$ ($p = 0.78$). Substituting the electoral component for the liberal component leaves the content coefficient essentially unchanged and the electoral term non-significant. The content of nationhood absorbs the institutional-liberalism association entirely, mirroring the multilevel horse race (SI-E).

SI-G. Performance models (the second face)

Replacing the predictor with perceived democratic performance (group-mean-centered) gives the contrast in the main text (its Figure 3). Pooled within-country slopes (M1-equivalent):

Outcome	Performance slope
National pride	+0.255 (0.015)***
National superiority	+0.143 (0.015)***
Civic membership	+0.084 (0.014)***
Ascriptive membership	−0.017 (0.016)
Anti-immigrant exclusion	−0.142 (0.016)***

Table SI-8: Pooled within-country performance slopes (M1-equivalent)

Note: SEs in parentheses; *** $p < .001$. Predictor is perceived democratic performance, group-mean-centered.

Performance evaluations travel positively with pride, superiority, and civic membership, and negatively with anti-immigrant exclusion. I exclude “pride in the way democracy works” as a performance outcome because it is near-tautological with the predictor. The substantive results above concern pride in non-democratic achievements.

SI-H. Descriptive regional associations

The within-country weighted correlations behind the main-text “map.” These are descriptive and weaker than the models, but show the same contrast.

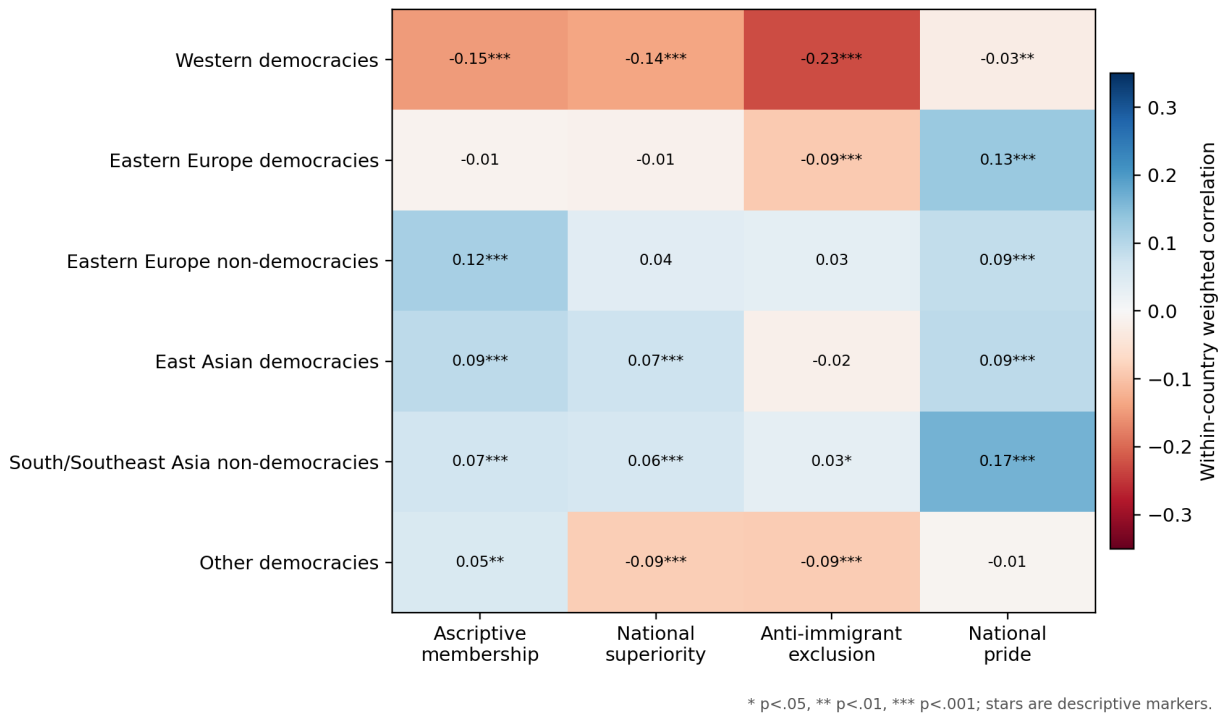


Figure SI-1: Democratic-rights endorsement and nationalism, by region-regime group

Note: Cell entries are within-country weighted correlations (ISSP combined weight, equal country weighting), averaged within each region-regime group. Within Western democracies the rights–exclusion correlations are negative; outside the West they weaken and, in the electoral autocracies, turn positive.

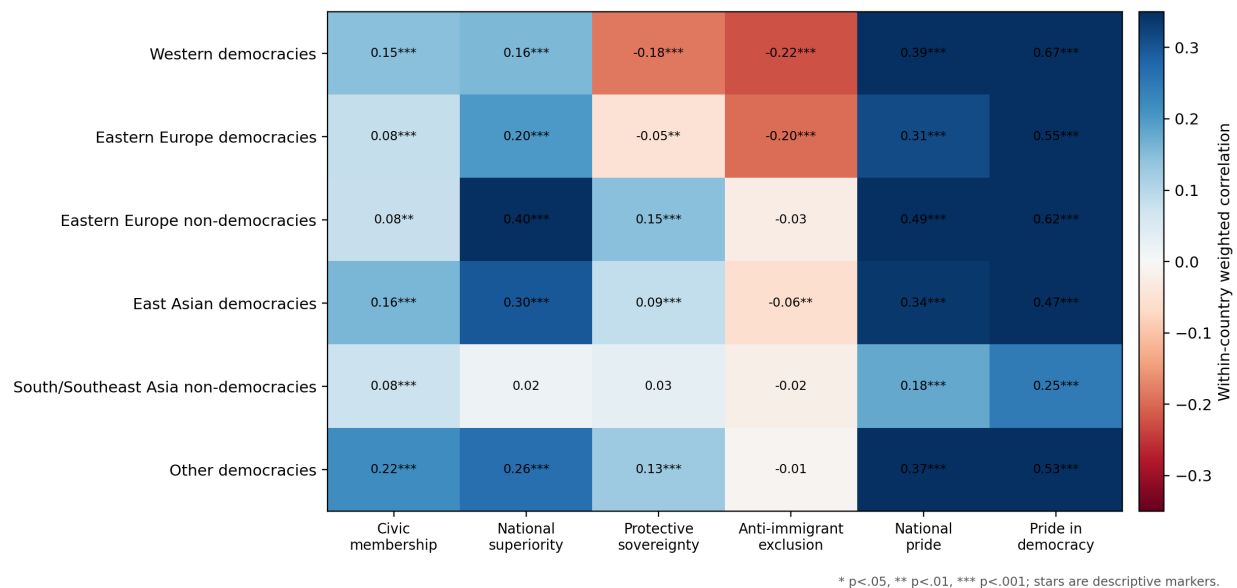


Figure SI-2: Perceived democratic performance and nationalism, by region-regime group

Note: Cell entries are within-country weighted correlations of perceived democratic performance with each nationalism measure, averaged within each region-regime group. Performance tracks pride and superiority across regions, in contrast to the rights pattern above.

SI-I. Country-specific adjusted slopes (all outcomes)

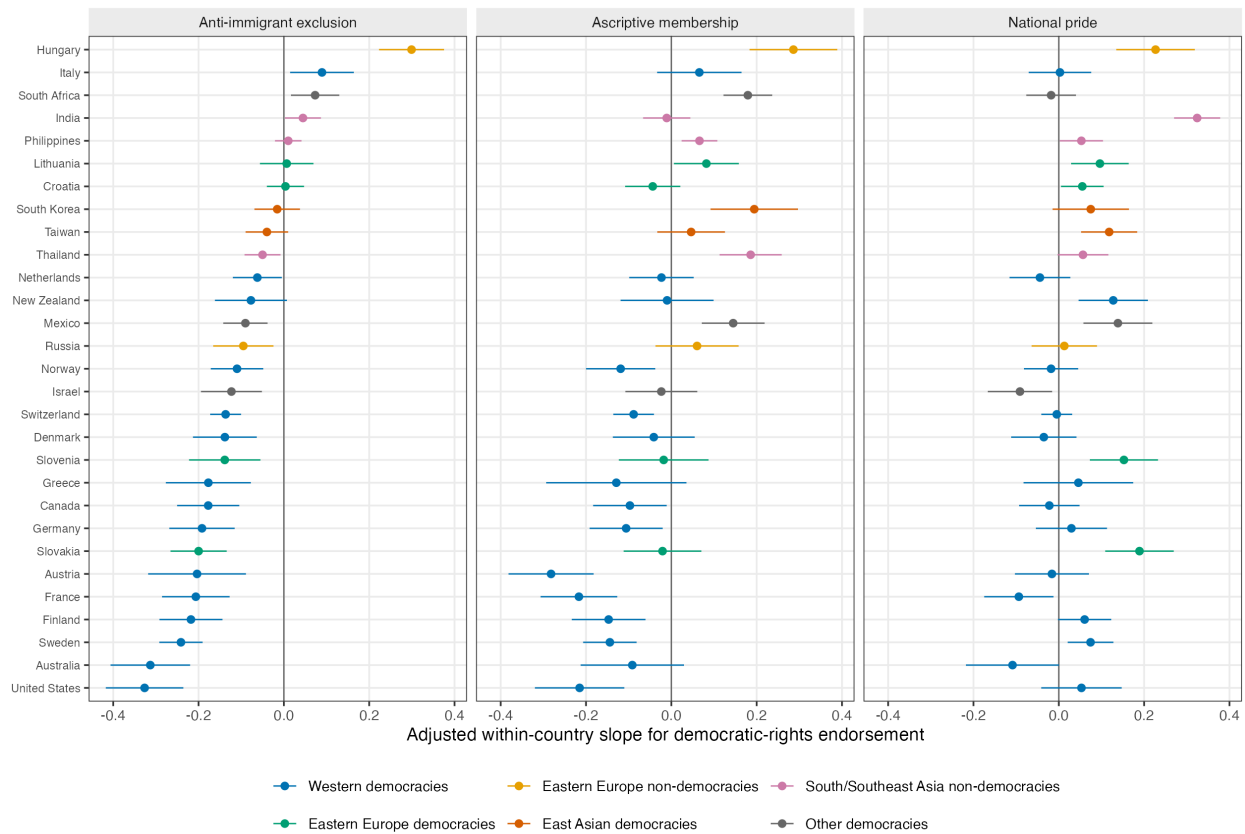


Figure SI-3: Country-specific adjusted slopes for democratic-rights endorsement, by outcome

Note: Points are country-specific within-country slopes of each outcome on democratic-rights endorsement, adjusted for individual controls (age, gender, education, left-right placement); bars are 95% confidence intervals and color denotes region-regime group. Countries share the anti-immigrant ordering of main-text Figure 1. The anti-immigrant panel reproduces that figure; the ascriptive and pride panels extend it to the other outcomes.

SI-J. Robustness

The reversal at the heart of the paper is not an artifact of the regime classification, the choice of index, or the weighting scheme, as five checks confirm.

Design-based weighted estimates agree with the model-based ones. The descriptive within-country correlations (SI-H, computed with WEIGHT_COM and equal country weighting) agree with the model-based estimates in sign and pattern. The main-text models are unweighted, and design-based weighting does not change the conclusions.

A regime binary reproduces the contrast. Splitting by the simple V-Dem democracy/non-democracy binary, the correlations between democratic-rights endorsement and exclusion are negative within democracies (anti-immigrant -0.18 , superiority -0.09 , ascriptive -0.08) and positive within the five non-democracies (ascriptive $+0.09$, superiority $+0.05$, pride $+0.13$). The binary is coarse (5 non-democracies) and is reported only as a robustness contrast; the continuous content-of-nationhood moderator is preferred.

An alternative democratic-rights index yields the same pattern. The four-item index, which adds “adequate standard of living,” reproduces the result.

The ascriptive outcome carries one caveat. Because the content-of-nationhood moderator is the country mean of ascriptive membership, the moderation of the *ascriptive* slope is partly mechanical, so the main text leads with anti-immigrant exclusion, where moderator and outcome are distinct.

The clustering unit does not matter. Germany and Israel each contribute two ISSP samples (*c_sample*); using *c_sample* (31 units) rather than country (29) as the grouping factor leaves results unchanged.

SI-K. Descriptive longitudinal panel (1995–2023)

The democratic-rights battery is 2023-only, so the relationship cannot be traced over time. As context, I track the *levels* of two exclusionary-nationalism measures available in all four ISSP National Identity rounds — ascriptive membership (born + religion importance) and anti-immigrant exclusion (crime, economy, jobs, immigration level) — for Western versus non-Western countries. This is descriptive and leans on cross-wave comparability, which the invariance results (SI-D) show is imperfect. Country composition also varies by wave, since the 1995 round fields only four Western countries. Read trajectories, not precise levels. The finer region-regime classification used throughout the rest of the analysis is too sparse to follow across waves here, so this panel falls back on a deliberately coarse West / non-West contrast. That split is a convenience of the thin longitudinal data, not a claim that either group is internally uniform or that the two mark a normative or civilizational divide. It is a dispassionate grouping of places by region and regime, and where the better-resolved groups differ in the 2023 cross-section I report those differences directly (SI-B, SI-H).

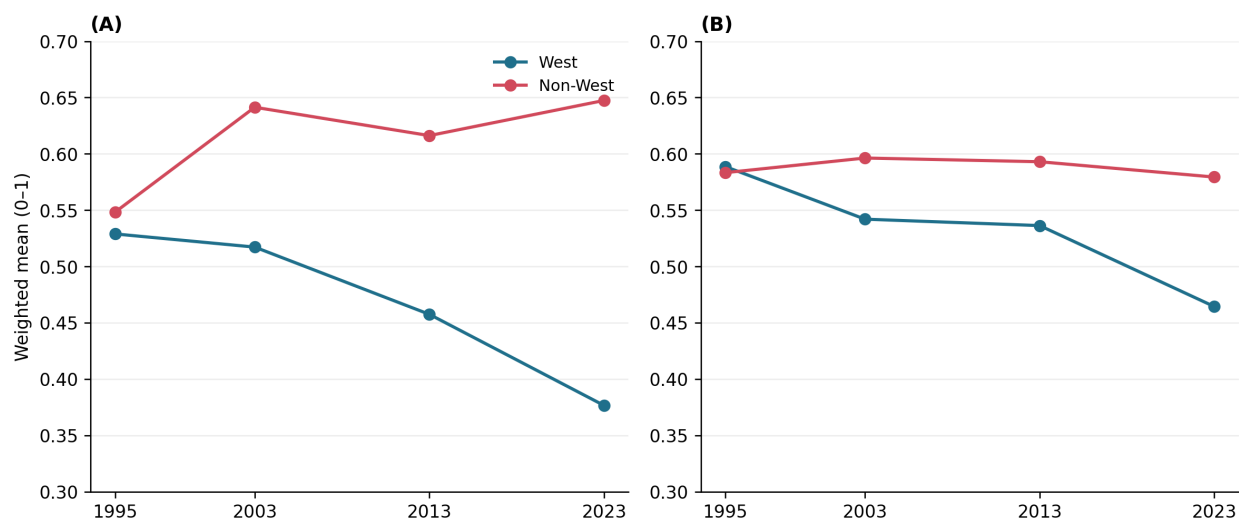


Figure SI-4: Exclusionary nationalism, West versus non-West, ISSP National Identity 1995–2023

Note: Weighted means by wave; panel (A) is the ascriptive (ethnic) conception of nationhood and panel (B) is anti-immigrant exclusion. Country composition varies by wave (1995 includes only four Western countries), and cross-wave comparability is imperfect (SI-D), so read trajectories rather than precise levels. The figure shows a long Western civic turn against flat non-Western levels.

Measure	Group	1995	2003	2013	2023
Ascriptive	West	0.53	0.52	0.46	0.38
	Non-West	0.55	0.64	0.62	0.65
Anti-immigrant	West	0.59	0.54	0.54	0.46
	Non-West	0.58	0.60	0.59	0.58

Table SI-9: Exclusionary nationalism by wave, West versus non-West (weighted means)

Note: Country composition varies by wave; read trajectories, not precise levels.

The descriptive picture is a long Western civic turn: ascriptive and anti-immigrant nationalism have fallen in Western publics since 1995 while remaining flat elsewhere. The civic character of Western nationhood that conditions the 2023 cross-section is thus the product of a multi-decade divergence, not a fixed cultural constant.

SI-L. Democratic socialization in Taiwan and South Korea

Taiwan and South Korea redefined their national projects and democratized recently, Taiwan across the 1990s (with the first direct presidential election in 1996) and South Korea in 1987–1988. Redefining the nation, and the political-cultural change that democratization sets in motion, takes a generation to consolidate rather than all at once. Political identities and orientations crystallize during the formative, “impressionable” years and then persist with comparative stability across the life course (Mannheim, 1952; Jennings and Niemi, 1981; Krosnick and Alwin, 1989; Neundorff and Smets, 2017), so a cohort that comes of age under one national-institutional settlement tends to carry its imprint forward. I bracket that formative window as ages 12–25, running from the onset of political awareness through early adulthood, and ask whether citizens whose entire window fell under democratic institutions hold more civic, less ascriptive conceptions of nationhood. A respondent is classified as democratically socialized if they reached age 12 at or after the transition, so that the whole 12–25 window post-dates it (born in or after 1984 in Taiwan, 1975 in South Korea). Cell entries are weighted means. Ascriptive membership and anti-immigrant exclusion run from 0 to 1 with higher values more exclusionary, and the civic-minus-ethnic column is the civic-membership advantage over ascriptive membership, where higher is more civic.

Country	Cohort	N	Ascriptive	Civic – ethnic	Anti-immigrant
Taiwan	Democratically socialized	426	0.33	+0.49	0.39
Taiwan	Earlier cohort	1,137	0.46	+0.41	0.47
South Korea	Democratically socialized	491	0.55	+0.18	0.55
South Korea	Earlier cohort	739	0.61	+0.16	0.55

Table SI-10: Conceptions of nationhood by democratic-socialization cohort, Taiwan and South Korea

Note: Cell entries are weighted means. “Democratically socialized” respondents reached age 12 at or after the transition (born in or after 1984 in Taiwan, 1975 in South Korea). Ascriptive membership and anti-immigrant exclusion run 0–1 with higher values more exclusionary; the civic-minus-ethnic column is the civic-membership advantage over ascriptive membership, where higher is more civic. The civic gradient is more than twice as steep in Taiwan.

The pattern matches the expectation. In Taiwan the democratically socialized cohort is markedly more civic. Its mean endorsement of ascriptive membership (0.33) sits 0.13 below the earlier cohort (0.46) and reaches the Western level, where the mean is about 0.36 (SI-B). In South Korea the same comparison

yields a much smaller gap (0.55 against 0.61), and even the younger cohort remains strongly ethnic in its conception of nationhood, well above the Western level. The generational gradient in the civic conception of nationhood is more than twice as steep in Taiwan as in South Korea. This comparison is observational and confounds cohort with life cycle, so it is suggestive rather than decisive. Comparing the cohort gap across the two cases nonetheless follows the design-based logic for separating cohort from life-cycle effects (Dinas and Stoker, 2014). A universal age effect would not produce a Taiwan gradient twice the Korean one, nor would it bring Taiwan's young cohort to Western civic levels. The pattern instead fits Taiwan's more thorough post-1990s shift toward a civic, territorial conception of the nation. This convergence bears on how the cross-section should be read. The civic character of Western nationhood is itself a recent, multi-decade development (SI-K), and Taiwan's democratically socialized cohort has reached a comparably civic conception within a single generation. The difference between civic and ethnic conceptions of nationhood is therefore one of historical and institutional trajectory rather than of fixed East/West essence. Taiwan's youngest citizens are the clearest case of an ethnically defined nation reaching a civic conception within a generation.

The reorientation shows up not only in the level of ascriptive nationhood but in the democratic-rights relationship itself. The table below reports the within-cohort correlation of democratic-rights endorsement with anti-immigrant exclusion and with ascriptive membership.

Country	Cohort	$r(\text{rights, anti-immigrant})$	$r(\text{rights, ascriptive})$
Taiwan	Democratically socialized	-0.10	-0.01
Taiwan	Earlier cohort	+0.02	+0.10
South Korea	Democratically socialized	+0.02	+0.14
South Korea	Earlier cohort	-0.04	+0.14

Table SI-11: Within-cohort correlation of democratic-rights endorsement with exclusion, Taiwan and South Korea
Note: Cell entries are within-cohort correlations of democratic-rights endorsement with anti-immigrant exclusion and with ascriptive membership, without controls. The Taiwanese democratically socialized cohort displays the Western, restraining pattern; the South Korean cohorts do not shift. Read as suggestive.

In Taiwan the democratically socialized cohort displays the Western, restraining pattern. Democratic-rights endorsement is negatively correlated with anti-immigrant exclusion (-0.10) and unrelated to

ascriptive membership (-0.01), whereas among the earlier cohort the same correlations are flat or positive ($+0.02$ and $+0.10$). In South Korea the relationship does not shift across cohorts. Democratic-rights endorsement remains positively associated with ascriptive nationhood in both the young and the old ($+0.14$), consistent with an ethnic conception that has not reoriented. These are subgroup correlations without controls and should be read as suggestive, but they show the paper's central moderation playing out within a single country over time.

SI-M. Reproducibility

The replication package holds the analysis scripts in `code/` and writes all derived tables and figures to `outputs/`. The scripts are:

- `issp2023_democracy_nationalism.py` — descriptive measures, regional correlations, heatmaps.
- `vdem_extract.R` — V-Dem `v15` indices for the 29 countries.
- `build_analysis_data.py` — assembles the analysis-ready individual file and country-level moderators (using the V-Dem indices above).
- `measurement_invariance.R` — multi-group CFA and alignment (`lavaan`, `semTools`, `sirt`).
- `multilevel_models.R` — random-slope models and cross-level interactions (`lme4`).
- `diagnostic_secondstage.R` — country-level second-stage regressions.
- `longitudinal_trends.py` — 1995–2023 harmonization.
- `cohort_test.py` — democratic-socialization cohort test (SI-L).
- `figures_v2.py` and `figures_ggrepel.R` — publication figures (the latter, in `ggplot2` with `ggrepel`, produces the two country-level figures and the supplementary slopes figure).

The driver `master.sh` runs these scripts in dependency order and writes all derived outputs to `outputs/`; the manuscript PDFs are then built with `make` in the manuscript source directory. `README.md` gives the figure/table-to-script crosswalk.

Data access

The ISSP 2023 microdata (ZA10010) are obtained free from the GESIS Data Archive after registration and are not redistributed here, and the earlier waves (ZA2880, ZA3910, ZA5950) are obtained the same way. V-Dem `v15` is retrieved through the `vdemdata` R package, installed with `remotes::install_github("vdeminstitute/vdemdata")`.

Software

The pipeline uses Python 3 (pandas, numpy, pyreadstat, scipy, matplotlib) and R 4.5 (lavaan, semTools, sirt, lme4, ggplot2, ggrepel, vdemdata), with pandoc and pdflatex for the manuscript. It is deterministic except for `sirt::invariance.alignment` (SI-D), whose optimizer is seeded for exact reproduction.

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